mates. I was happy that Maa would finally see the disciplined soldier inside her mischievous daughter.

As my aircraft left the tarmac, I saw myself advancing towards a new horizon where the most important purpose of my life awaited. But the path was still laid with back-breaking obstacles, tests so challenging they would go beyond my limits. All I needed to do was remain resilient. All that any cadet needs in the academy is to keep doing everything they are asked to—without giving much thought to it. The military is not the place for those who apply logic to orders; the military is for those who know how to follow orders in letter and spirit. Because when in war, logic induces fear and fear induces cowardice. But those who are only trained to follow orders fail to recognize fear. Those who follow orders are the ones who make a difference. And this entire process begins in the academy itself. So when I flew my first sortie, I realized this was exactly what I needed to do, and I promised myself I would keep going and face whatever came my way. The flying training had just begun. The first aim was to qualify for a solo flight. I could not wait to achieve this aim, little knowing then that this would put me in a situation I would never have wished for.